

pulled it back through the Feed rollers—the rollers that feed the paper in the printer—the toner on the paper could fall onto the rollers. This could cause following copies to come out dirty.

❑ Avoiding paper jams

The thumb-rule is not to overload the printer. Too many papers can lead to pressure on the paper separation tabs, and result in double feeds. Special care is needed to feed specialty papers such as photo paper. Since these are thicker, the best thing to do is to feed them manually, one by one. Also, do not use transparencies, or other media that cannot tolerate high levels of heat. Cleaning your printer, especially the roller, plays an important part in avoiding jams. This is because dirty rollers hamper the movement of paper inside the printer.

❑ Static electricity

The laser printers that are most affected by static electricity are those based on the Corona Wire technology.

Static electricity increases because of two things—wind or movement, and dry air. In winter, the problem is compounded by low humidity, and dry heat in offices and homes. You may notice random black streaks, or blotches of toner on your pages because of this. To remedy this, the humidity level in the room should be at least 35 per cent. Further, you can decrease the static

electricity around the printer using a solution comprising one tablespoon of liquid fabric softener and about 300 ml of water—spray this on the carpet around the printer. Do not spray it directly onto the printer.

❑ AB switches

Be careful when using manual AB switches for printer sharing. In most cases, the



printer's warranty becomes void if you use them. A better option would be to use electronic switches.

❑ Ozone filters

One more component that needs to be taken care of is the ozone filter. A clogged ozone filter can harm your printer by increasing its temperature, and by blocking the airflow—thus slowing down the fan. A fan that's slow causes harm to printer components, and the ozone produced oxidizes them. Change the ozone filter once in 6 months.

❑ Corona wire

Some of the older laser printers, such as the HP Laserjet II and III, are based on corona wire technology. Special care

is needed to clean them.

Most vertical streaking caused by a dirty Corona wire will be hazy or uneven, and intermittent. The wire is found in a metal furrow that runs the width of the paper, along the bottom. It may be covered with angled wire. The wire is very thin, like a strand of hair, and care should be taken not to break it while cleaning. First, the furrow should be cleaned with a vacuum cleaner, and then with a cotton swab dampened with water or peroxide. After all the toner is removed from the floor and walls of the trough, gently brush the length of the corona wire with a dry cotton swab to remove any dust or debris.

Many toner cartridges have a charge wire inside them. Removing dust from this will prevent most vertical streaking.

Inkjet Printers

❑ Cleaning the head

The head cleaning utility, that comes with almost all printers, does not always do an efficient job. Often, ink deposits build up on the end of the print head, causing the cartridge to function sub-optimally. It's better to clean the head manually, to ensure proper functioning and crisper prints. Clean the

head by wiping it gently with a soft cotton cloth—don't use tissues since they tend to stick onto the head. Snap the cartridge in and out a couple times, to get a good connection after cleaning.

❑ General Cleaning

If the printer is printing in streaks, and is smearing, there's excess ink in the carriage area. Open the printer and remove the cartridges. Fold a letter-sized piece of paper in half, and then in half again the other way, so that it is quartered. Insert this paper into the regular feed slot or space. Move the paper to the left and to the right, to remove excess ink under the carriage. Once the excess ink is removed, the printer should resume printing normally.

Apart from this, do call your technician at least once a year to get your printer cleaned thoroughly. There are parts that are impossible to get at without disassembling the machine. These need to be attended to by a professional.

Printing Images

There are a few general rules that can be followed to print high quality photographs. The first rule is to use specially designed photo papers. Several well-known brands such as HP, Kodak and others have their own brand of photo papers. The second rule is to use a photo cartridge. Your inkjet printer will have to support this, however. The third rule is to



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